abruptly stopped talking at the top of the hour, turned up his radio, listened to the news bulletin, and then resumed the conversation. “I just wanted to know if we were at war,” he told his slightly bewildered guest.

War remains a constant. The 2014 conflict, though it seemed to start abruptly, was also inevitable. As this book goes to press, there is renewed talk of a fourth round in Gaza, or a third on the northern border with Lebanon. The question is not “if”, only “when”, and what will spark it.

One can debate whether or not this inevitability is a permanent fixture of life in Israel—whether a different government could forge a lasting peace agreement with the Palestinians and the Arab world. It is fair to say that Hamas, which is plagued by deep internal divisions (and countenances violence against Israeli civilians), is not a viable partner for a long-term peace. But it could be a partner to interim agreements, which would provide an opportunity to change the political and economic realities in Gaza. As far back as the late 1990s, the group’s leadership offered Israel a long-term *hudna*, or truce. The Israeli right insists that it will not negotiate with a terrorist organization. Yet even before the 2014 truce, the leader of the Israeli right, Benjamin Netanyahu, had already negotiated two separate deals with Hamas: the 2011 prisoner swap that freed Gilad Shalit, and the cease-fire that ended the brief 2012 war.

Many Israelis, however, don’t bother with that debate. They accept the inevitability. The proof for this would be seen a few months after the 2014 war, when Netanyahu dissolved his government and called early elections: lawmakers barely mentioned the war. They can accept it because, for much of the country, the 2014 war was a nuisance. Life did not grind to a halt in Tel Aviv or Jerusalem. It was far more serious for the residents in the “Gaza envelope”, some of whom never returned home, and of course for the soldiers who fought it. Hamas surprised even itself with its performance—fighting for more than seven weeks, deploying new offensive tactics like attack tunnels. But, to no one’s surprise, it ultimately suffered a strategic defeat.

Israelis are fond of the phrase “status quo”. Hebrew even borrows it as a loan expression from Latin. One lesson from reporting on Israel and Palestine, however, is that the status quo is never truly static. This is certainly true on the Palestinian side, where the ever-worsening misery in Gaza has fueled the birth of radical *salafi* groups. Their numbers are small—the largest has perhaps 300–400 members, according to both Israeli and